

the Internet. This map includes both wired and wireless connections that your computer might be routing through in order to get to the World Wide Web. You can access a full view of this map by clicking on the “View full map” text link.

Next up, the Center displays individual connections under Vista. These generally include any onboard network ports, or LAN cards, or even wireless access points and routers. Each such connection is tagged with common tasks that you can perform around that network resource. As mentioned in Chapter 6: Security, under the Firewall section, each time you connect to a new network, Vista asks you to identify the network with a name and either a Private or a Public tag. Based on this, Vista creates firewall settings for each network. You can change these settings by clicking on the Customize text link to the right of each individual connection.



The Network and Sharing Center

A Private network is appropriate for a home or a small office network, when you know and trust the people and devices on the network. For a Private network, Network discovery, which allows you to see other computers and devices on a network and allows other network users to see your computer, is On by default. A Public network is generally one that you access from a public place—such as a coffee house or a cyber-café, or an airport terminal.

For a Public network, Vista turns off Network discovery. The Public tag is designed to keep your computer from being visible to other computers around you and to help protect your computer from malicious software from the Internet.